2

His Family and Early Life

'I have reported every good and evil I have seen of father and brother and set down the actuality of every fault and virtue of relative and stranger. May the reader excuse me; may the listener take me not to task.'[*]

—Babur

If you must trust something in history, it must be the primary source. One can surely argue though that how can one be so sure about the primary source giving the exact version of the happenings of a period? The answer is that indeed we can't grant the certificate of honesty to the person attributed to a particular source, but the corroborations with other primary sources on the same subject can certainly bring us closer to the truth. Moreover, in this game of history, you must choose something as the truth and only then can the narrative be weaved into the contemporary period of the incident we are referring to. If a primary source can't be trusted, then nothing else can ever be trusted either.

Whether you like it or not, the Tīmūrids themselves have been the primary source for their history through their writings. It is said that children always see the most ideal man in their father. The same must have been the case with Babur. Remember that being a conqueror was a heroic act back then.

Perhaps what he writes about his father, Umar Shaikh Mīrzā, might have been an exaggerated account. But as mentioned earlier, we have no choice but to believe his words. At the same time, largely the folklore of the region, along with mention of historical incidences support Babur's narrative.

In Babur's opinion, his father Mīrzā, being highly striving and a go-getter, always looked for opportunities to conquer. He was a true conqueror. Although he was not victorious in all his missions, his passion to conquer never ended. On his mission to Samarkand, he tasted defeat on several occasions. At various junctures, he had to retire against his will as adverse situations engulfed the battlefields. But he never let those junctures demotivate him.

His father has described his (maternal) grandfather Yunus Khān[1] an aid. His grandfather was the chief of the Mongols (Moghūls). Once, Umar had called his father-in-law into the country.[2] Before coming to Mīrzā's country, Yunus Khān